

Related Species A decoction of the bark of the Caribbean *C. bahamensis* is used for liver and kidney infections, and a decoction of the wood is used for diabetes. An infusion of the leaves of *C. pulcherrima* (native to Asia and Africa) is taken for liver problems and mouth ulcers.

Calamintha ascendens
syn. *C. sylvatica*, *C. officinalis*
(Lamiaceae)

Calamint

Description Mint-scented perennial growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has hairy oval leaves, and purple flowers in late summer.

Habitat & Cultivation Calamint grows wild in Europe and Asia from the British Isles eastward to Iran, especially in the Mediterranean region. It flourishes along roads and in dry places.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Calamint contains a volatile oil (about 0.35%) consisting mainly of pulegone.

History & Folklore In classical legend, calamint had the power to drive away the Basilisk, a serpent credited with the ability to kill with its gaze or breath.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Calamint stimulates sweating, and hence helps lower fevers. It also settles gas and indigestion. It is expectorant, and is a good cough and cold remedy. This range of applications makes it a good medicinal herb for mild respiratory infections. It should preferably be mixed with other herbs such as yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56) and thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143).

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Calluna vulgaris (Ericaceae)

Heather, Ling

Description Small, branched shrub growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has tiny leaves and white or pink to pale-purple flowers growing on spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Heather grows in temperate regions of the northern hemisphere. It is found on heaths, moors, bogs, and in open woods. The herb is gathered when in flower in late summer.

Parts Used Flowering tips.

Constituents Heather contains flavonoids, arbutin, tannin, and an alkaloid, ericodin. This constituent has a strongly disinfectant effect within the bladder and urinary tubules.

History & Folklore If the “*erica*” that Dioscorides discusses in his 1st century CE *Materia*

Medica is indeed heather, as has been surmised, then the flowering tips were used in classical times to treat snake bite. Galen (131–200 CE) wrote of the plant's ability to induce sweating. The rootstock of heather is made into musical pipes, the foliage provides mattress stuffing, and the flowers produce a delicate honey. White heather is considered very lucky, especially in Scotland.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Heather is a good urinary antiseptic and diuretic, disinfecting the urinary tract and mildly increasing urine production. Besides its role in treating cystitis and inflammatory bladder conditions, heather has been used to treat kidney and bladder stones. Cleansing and detoxifying, it is helpful for rheumatism, arthritis, and gout. A hot poultice of heather tips is a traditional remedy for chilblains and rheumatism.



Camellia sinensis syn. *Thea sinensis*
(Theaceae)

Tea

Description Evergreen shrub clipped to 5 ft (1.5 m) in cultivation, with leathery, dark green leaves and fragrant white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Cultivated principally in India, Sri Lanka, and China, tea has been grown since the earliest times.

Parts Used Leaves, buds.

Constituents Tea contains xanthines, caffeine (1–5%), theobromine, tannins including polyphenols, flavonoids, fats, and vitamin C. Green tea contains significant levels of polyphenols; black tea, which is produced by a process of fermentation, has lower levels.

History & Folklore In China and Japan many rituals have developed around tea drinking. Significantly it is mostly green tea that is drunk in this way.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Due to its astringency, tea is useful in digestive infections, helping to tighten up the mucous membranes of the gut and reduce looseness. A strong brew of tea

may be used to soothe irritated eyelids, insect stings, swellings, and sunburn, and in an emergency, if nothing better is at hand, tea makes a serviceable treatment for minor burns. In Ayurvedic medicine tea is considered astringent and a nerve tonic. The caffeine in tea may help to relieve headaches, though less effectively than coffee (*Coffea arabica*, p. 192). In light of research, green tea is recognized as being a much healthier drink than black tea.

Research Green tea's strong antioxidant activity is due to polyphenols, which give the leaf potential as a cancer preventative.

The high intake of green tea in China and Japan is thought to be partly responsible for the low incidence of cancer in these countries. Clinical trials indicate that green tea may help to promote weight loss and treat hepatitis, and there is the suggestion that it helps to prevent tooth decay. A recent clinical trial indicated that green tea has a genoprotective action, helping to prevent degenerative changes within the body, and potentially slowing the aging process. A 2013 clinical trial found that green tea extract taken by women for 4 months successfully shrank uterine fibroids.



Tea leaves are picked throughout the year and used both as a beverage and medicinally.